TOPIC 2 · FOUNDATIONS OF INSTRUCTIONAL PLANNING AND PROFESSIONAL STANDARDS

Writing Measurable, Achievable Lesson Objectives with the ABCD Model

A study reference for student teachers. Use it to plan your daily lessons, check your objectives before you submit a plan, and revise for the topic assessment.

Learning outcomes

By the end of this topic, you will be able to:

1. Explain how professional standards guide day-to-day planning decisions.
2. Describe backward design as a way to align standards, objectives, and assessment.
3. Identify the four parts of an ABCD objective: **Audience**, **Behavior**, **Condition**, and **Degree**.
4. Write daily objectives that are **measurable** and **achievable**, and align them with activities and assessment.

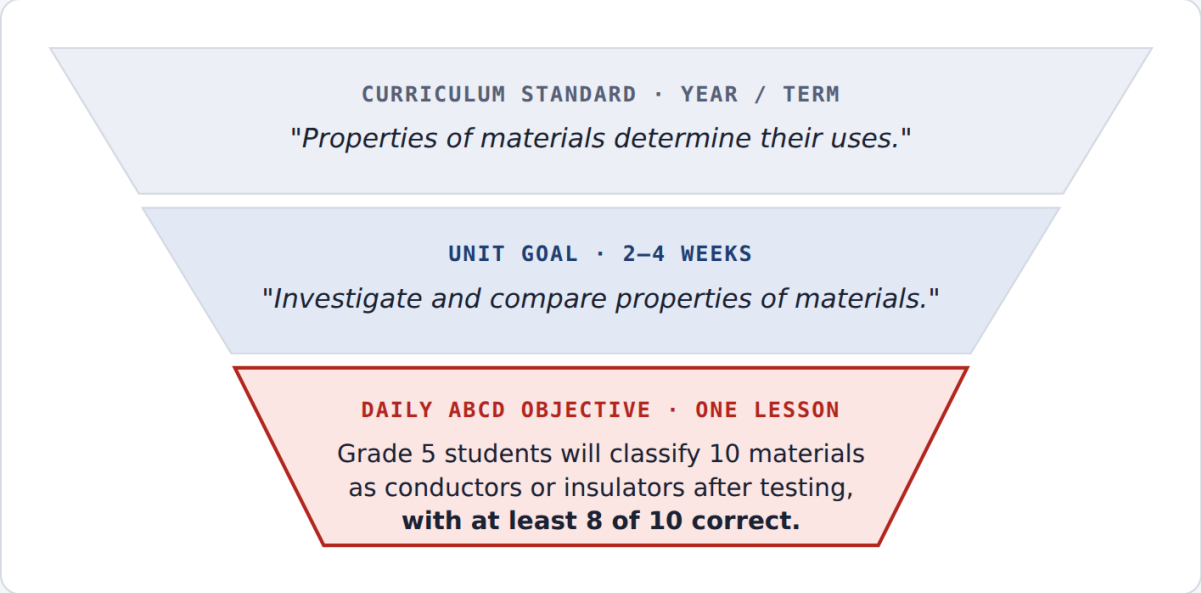
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1. How Professional Standards Guide Day-to-Day Planning

Two kinds of standards shape every lesson you plan. **Professional teaching standards** describe what a competent teacher does, including planning instruction from knowledge of content, learners, and curriculum (for example, InTASC Standard 7, "Planning for Instruction"; use the standards that apply in your own setting). **Curriculum standards** describe what students should know and be able to do.

Type	Answers the question	Effect on your daily plan
Professional teaching standards	*How well* do I plan and teach?	Sets the quality bar: clear objectives, planning for diverse learners, using assessment data, reflecting.
Curriculum / content standards	*What* must students learn?	Every daily objective must trace back to a curriculum standard or learning outcome.



Infographic 1. *The planning funnel. Standards are broad and long-term; a daily objective is one small, checkable step toward them.*

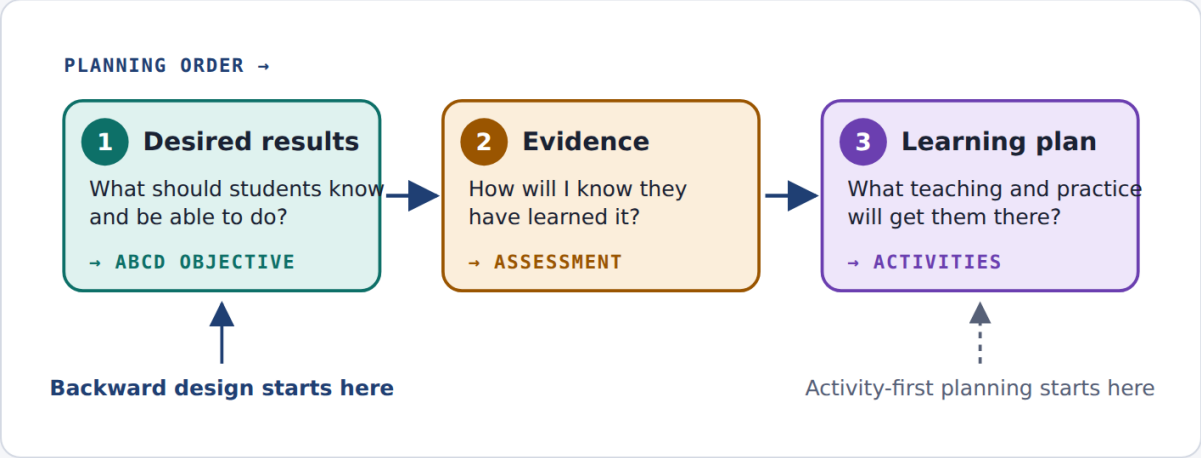
Daily decisions that standards inform

Decision	How the standard guides it
What to teach today	The next manageable step toward the standard.
How deep to go	The verb in the standard (*identify* vs. *analyze*) tells you the thinking level.
Which activities to use	Activities must practice the exact behavior named in the objective.
How to check learning	The assessment must measure the objective, not something else.

Decision	How the standard guides it
How to differentiate	Professional standards expect you to plan supports for different learners.
What to do tomorrow	Today's assessment results shape tomorrow's objective.

2. Backward Design: Start with the End in Mind

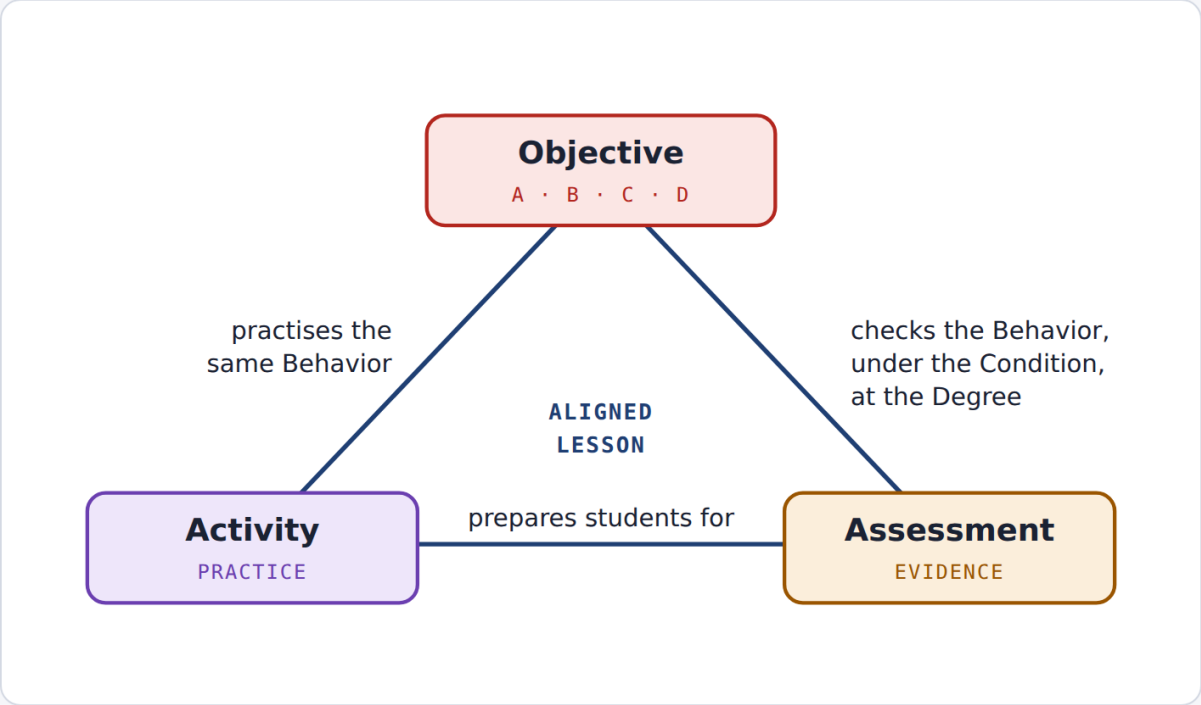
Backward design (Wiggins & McTighe, *Understanding by Design*) reverses the usual habit of choosing activities first. You decide what students should learn, then how you will know they learned it, and only then how you will teach it.



Infographic 2. *The three stages of backward design and what each one produces in a daily lesson plan.*

Stage	Key question	In a daily lesson plan
1. Desired results	What should students know and be able to do?	Select the standard, then write the ABCD objective(s).
2. Acceptable evidence	How will I know they have learned it?	Design the assessment. It must match the objective's Behavior, Condition, and Degree.
3. Learning plan	What teaching and practice will get them there?	Plan the introduction, modelling, guided practice, and independent practice.

A well-written ABCD objective **already contains its assessment**. The Behavior says what students will do, the Condition says the setting and tools, and the Degree gives the pass line. That is why objective writing is the key skill in daily planning.

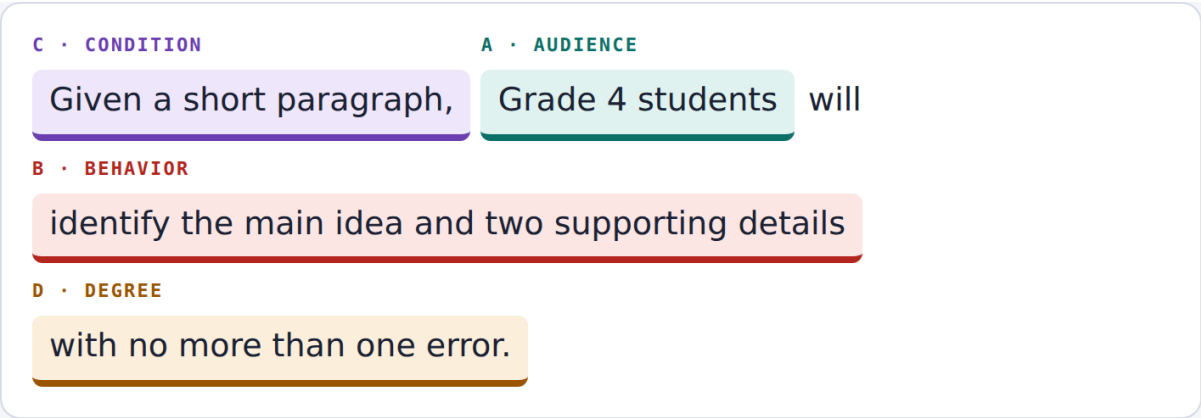


Infographic 3. *The alignment triangle. If one side does not connect, the lesson is misaligned.*

> **Alignment test:** read your objective, main activity, and assessment side by side. If a student does well in the activity, are they ready for the assessment? Does the assessment use the same behavior and conditions, at the stated level?

3. The ABCD Model

The ABCD model (from Heinich, Molenda, Russell & Smaldino, building on Mager) builds an objective from four parts. Each part answers one question.

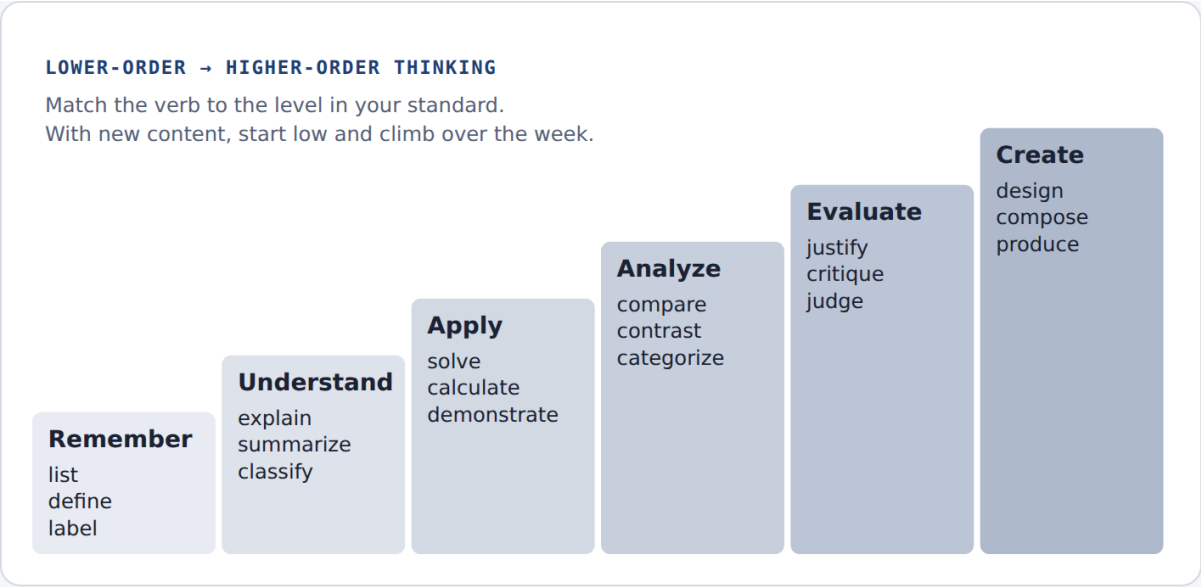


Infographic 4. *Anatomy of an ABCD objective. The order can change (the Condition often comes first), but all four parts should be there.*

Part	Question	Guidance	Examples
A · Audience	*Who* will learn?	Name the learners. Write about the student, never the teacher.	Grade 3 students; Group B learners
B · Behavior	*What* will they do?	One observable, measurable action verb plus the content. This is the most important part.	list, solve, compare, write
C · Condition	*Under what circumstances?*	What students are given, allowed to use, or limited by when they show the behavior.	given a map; without a calculator; after reading the text
D · Degree	*How well?*	The success criterion: accuracy, number correct, time limit, or rubric level.	8 of 10; 80%; rubric level 3; within 10 minutes

4. Choosing Measurable Verbs

The Behavior verb decides whether an objective is measurable. Pick a verb you could **see or hear** a student do, at the thinking level your standard asks for. The revised Bloom's taxonomy (Anderson & Krathwohl) is a useful guide.



Infographic 5. *The Bloom's staircase: six levels of thinking, each with verbs you can observe and measure.*

Level	What students do	Measurable verbs
Remember	Recall facts and basic concepts	list, name, define, label, recall, match

Level	What students do	Measurable verbs
Understand	Explain ideas or concepts	explain, summarize, paraphrase, classify, describe
Apply	Use information in a new situation	solve, use, demonstrate, calculate, construct
Analyze	Break into parts, draw connections	compare, contrast, categorize, distinguish, organize
Evaluate	Justify a decision or position	judge, justify, critique, defend, recommend
Create	Produce new or original work	design, compose, write, plan, produce

Verbs to avoid in the Behavior

These describe what happens inside a student's head, so you cannot observe or measure them directly: *understand, know, learn, appreciate, be aware of, be familiar with, grasp, realize, believe*.

> **Fix:** ask "What would I see or hear a student do to show they understand?" That action is your verb. *Understand fractions* becomes *compare two fractions using <, >, or =*.

5. Making Objectives Measurable and Achievable

Every daily objective must pass two tests. **Measurable** means you can see the learning and check it against a clear standard. **Achievable** means your students, with what they already know, can realistically reach it in one lesson with the resources you have.

Is it MEASURABLE? Ask:	Is it ACHIEVABLE? Ask:
• Can I **see or hear** the behavior? • Will students **produce evidence**: an answer, product, or performance? • Does the Degree have a **number, criterion, or rubric level**? • Would **two teachers agree** on whether a student met it? • Can I check it **by the end of the lesson**?	• **Time:** can students learn and show it within the lesson? • **Prior knowledge:** do they have the skills it builds on? • **Scope:** is it one step of the standard, not the whole unit? • **Degree:** is the target realistic for a first attempt (often 70–80%, or 4 of 5)? • **Resources and learners:** are the materials available, and does it suit students' age, language, and needs?



Infographic 6. *The objective matrix. Aim for the top-right box every time.*

How each ABCD part controls both qualities

Part	Makes it measurable by…	Makes it achievable by…
Audience	Naming exactly whose performance is checked.	Reminding you to plan for these learners' level and needs.
Behavior	Using an observable verb.	Choosing a thinking level and amount of content that fits one lesson.
Condition	Fixing the setting, so every student is judged the same way.	Adding supports (word bank, example, manipulatives) that make a hard skill reachable.
Degree	Giving a clear pass line (8 of 10, 80%, rubric level 3).	Setting a realistic first-lesson target: not 100%, and not so low it means nothing.

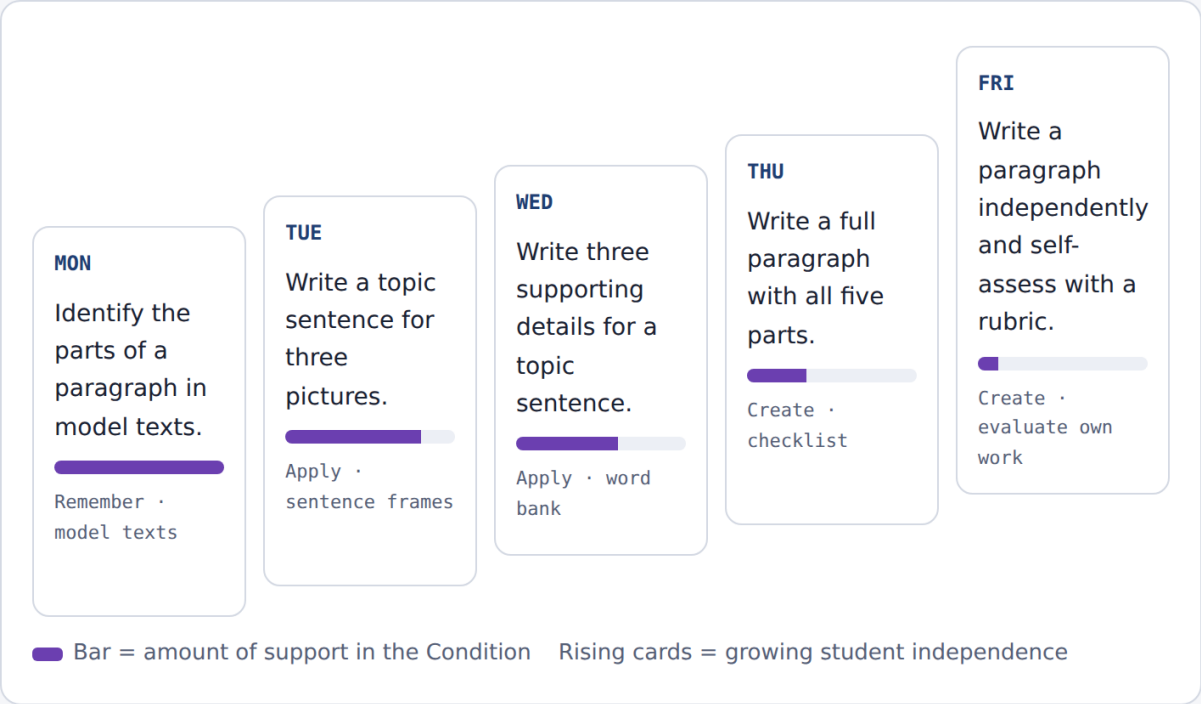
From unachievable to achievable

Too much for one lesson	Why	Achievable revision
Grade 7 students will solve all types of linear equations with 100% accuracy.	A whole unit; perfection on day one.	**Given ten one-step equations, Grade 7 students** will **solve for the unknown with at least 8 correct**.

Too much for one lesson	Why	Achievable revision
Grade 5 students will design and carry out a full investigation on plant growth.	Takes weeks, not one lesson.	**Given a research question, Grade 5 students** will **identify the independent, dependent, and controlled variables with all three correct**.
Grade 10 students will critique five poems in 20 minutes.	Too much evaluation for the time.	**After a guided reading of one poem, Grade 10 students** will **justify their interpretation of its theme in a paragraph using at least two quotations**.
Grade 2 students will write a five-paragraph essay with no spelling errors.	Beyond the age level; 100% is unrealistic.	**Using a sentence frame and word bank, Grade 2 students** will **write three sentences about a family member with a capital letter and full stop in at least 2 of 3**.

Break a standard into achievable daily steps

One broad standard usually needs several lessons. Make each day one achievable step. Over the week, reduce the support and raise the thinking level.



Infographic 7. *The weekly staircase. Each daily objective is achievable, and together they reach the standard.*

6. Writing an ABCD Objective Step by Step

1. **Start from the standard.** Copy the curriculum standard or unit goal.

2. **Choose today's step.** What part can students realistically achieve in this lesson?
3. **Name the Audience**: who are the learners?
4. **Select the Behavior**: one measurable verb at the right level, plus the content.
5. **Set the Condition**: what students are given, may use, or are limited by.
6. **Define the Degree**: a realistic, checkable pass line.
7. **Read it aloud.** Is it one clear sentence that another teacher would assess the same way?
8. **Write the assessment from it.** If you cannot, revise the objective.

Worked example: Grade 7 Mathematics

Step	Decision
Standard	Solve real-world problems involving ratios and rates.
Today's step	Use unit rates to compare prices.
Audience	Grade 7 students
Behavior	calculate unit prices and decide which is the better buy (Apply)
Condition	given five pairs of supermarket price labels and a calculator
Degree	correctly for at least 4 of the 5 pairs
Objective	**Given five pairs of price labels and a calculator, Grade 7 students** will **calculate unit prices and decide which is the better buy correctly for at least 4 of the 5 pairs**.
Aligned assessment	An exit ticket with five new pairs of price labels. Students show the calculation and circle the better buy.

Weak vs. strong objectives

Weak	Problem	Strong ABCD version
Students will understand photosynthesis.	Vague verb; no condition or degree.	**Using a labelled diagram, Grade 6 students** will **explain the inputs and outputs of photosynthesis**, **naming all three inputs and both outputs**.
The teacher will show how to write a paragraph.	Describes the teacher, not the learner.	**Given a graphic organizer, Grade 3 students** will **write a paragraph with a topic sentence, three details, and a closing sentence**, **including all five parts**.

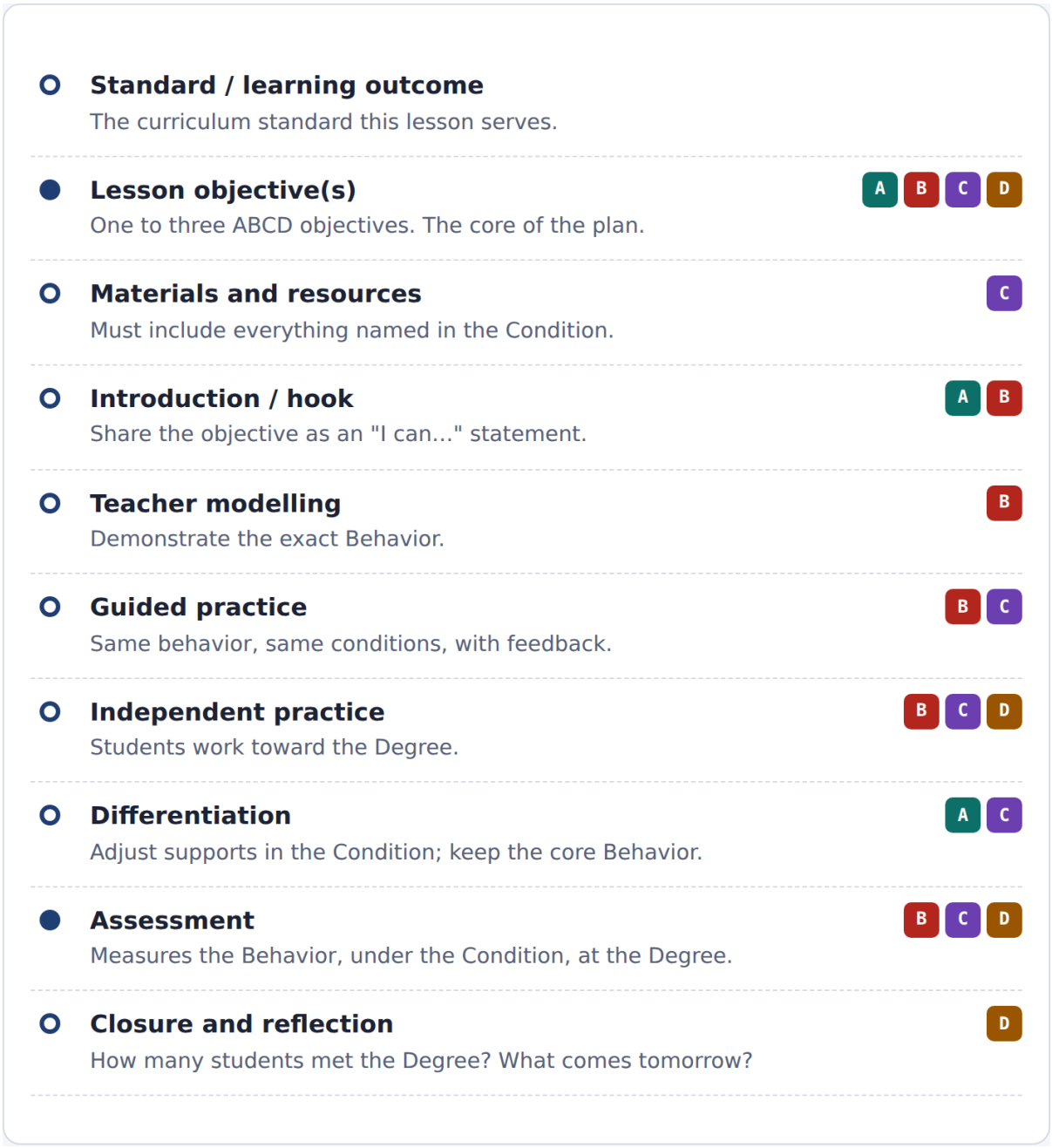
Weak	Problem	Strong ABCD version
Students will complete page 45.	An activity, not a learning outcome.	**Without a calculator, Grade 4 students** will **multiply two-digit by one-digit numbers with at least 80% accuracy**.
Students will know the parts of speech.	Vague and too broad for one lesson.	**Given ten sentences, Grade 2 students** will **underline the noun and circle the verb in each with at least 8 correct**.

Common mistakes

- Writing what the **teacher** will do instead of the student.
- Writing an **activity** ("complete the worksheet") instead of a learning outcome.
- Using **vague verbs** such as understand, know, or learn.
- Putting **several behaviors** in one objective. Write separate objectives.
- A Degree you **cannot check** ("will do well").
- A Condition that **does not match the assessment** ("using a calculator" when the quiz bans them).
- An objective that is **too big** for one lesson, or a Degree of 100% on a first attempt.

7. Where Objectives Sit in the Daily Lesson Plan

The objective goes near the top of the plan, and every later section links back to it. Most lessons need one to three objectives. The letters show which ABCD part each section depends on.



Infographic 8. *The lesson plan flow, showing which ABCD part each section depends on.*

Turn the objective into a student-friendly target

For	Wording
Your plan	Given five pairs of price labels and a calculator, Grade 7 students will calculate unit prices and decide which is the better buy correctly for at least 4 of the 5 pairs.
Students ("I can")	"I can find the price of one item so I can tell which deal is better."
Success criterion	"I get at least 4 out of 5 right on my exit ticket."

8. Practice and Self-Check

Objective planning template

Use this template to draft each objective for your lesson plan.

Part	Your decision
Curriculum standard	
Today's step	
A · Audience	
B · Behavior (verb + content)	
C · Condition	
D · Degree	
Full objective	
Aligned assessment	
Main activity	

Quick quiz: what is the problem?

Decide whether each objective is **(a) measurable and achievable**, **(b) not measurable**, or **(c) not achievable**.

1. Students will understand the causes of World War I.
2. Given ten one-step equations, Grade 7 students will solve for x with at least 8 correct.
3. Grade 1 students will read a 300-word story aloud with no errors.
4. The teacher will explain the rules for adding fractions.
5. Grade 5 students will design, carry out, and report a full science investigation in one lesson.

Activity 1: Label the parts

Mark A, B, C, and D in each objective.

1. Using a ruler, Grade 3 students will measure the length of five classroom objects to the nearest centimetre.
2. After reading the story, students will sequence six events in the correct order with no errors.
3. Grade 8 students will write a persuasive letter of at least 200 words, using the checklist provided, scoring 3 or higher on the rubric.

Activity 2: From standard to daily objectives

Choose a curriculum standard from your specialization. Using backward design, write:

1. Two ABCD objectives at different Bloom's levels for one lesson.
2. An aligned assessment for each objective.
3. One main activity for each objective.
4. One sentence naming the professional teaching standard your plan shows, and how.

Self-check before you submit a lesson plan

✓	Criterion
☐	It links to a specific curriculum standard or learning outcome.
☐	**A:** it names the learners and focuses on the student, not the teacher.
☐	**B:** it uses one observable verb at the right thinking level.
☐	**C:** it states the materials, setting, or limits, and these match the assessment.
☐	**D:** it states a clear, realistic success criterion.
☐	It describes a learning outcome, not an activity.
☐	**Measurable:** I know exactly what evidence I will collect and what counts as success.
☐	**Achievable:** it fits the lesson time, builds on prior knowledge, and sets a realistic Degree.
☐	Another teacher could assess it the same way I would.

Answer key

Quick quiz

1. **(b) Not measurable.** "Understand" cannot be observed. Try: "Given a timeline, Grade 9 students will explain three causes of World War I, with a supporting fact for each."
2. **(a) Measurable and achievable.** All four parts are present, the verb is observable, and 8 of 10 is a realistic target.
3. **(c) Not achievable.** The text is too long and "no errors" is unrealistic for Grade 1. Try a 50-word decodable text with at least 90% of words read correctly.

4. **(b) Not measurable.** It describes the teacher, not the students.
5. **(c) Not achievable.** Three large behaviors in one lesson. Break it into daily steps across the week.

Activity 1

1. **C: using a ruler** · **A: Grade 3 students** · **B: measure the length of five objects** · **D: to the nearest centimetre**
2. **C: after reading the story** · **A: students** · **B: sequence six events** · **D: in the correct order with no errors**
3. **A: Grade 8 students** · **B: write a persuasive letter** · **C: using the checklist provided** · **D: at least 200 words, rubric level 3 or higher**

9. Summary, Key Terms, and References

Summary

- Professional standards set *how well* you plan; curriculum standards set *what* students learn.
- Daily objectives break broad standards into small, measurable steps.
- Backward design: results (objective) first, then evidence (assessment), then learning experiences (activities).
- ABCD: **Audience**, **Behavior**, **Condition**, **Degree**.
- A strong objective is **measurable** (observable verb and clear pass line) and **achievable** (one realistic step for these students in one lesson).

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Alignment	The match between standards, objectives, activities, and assessment.
Backward design	Planning that starts from desired results and evidence before choosing activities.
Learning objective	A statement of what learners will be able to do by the end of a lesson.
Measurable verb	An action verb describing performance you can observe.
Achievable	Realistic for these learners, in this time, with these resources.
Success criterion	The level of performance that shows the objective was met (the Degree).

References

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